

An apex predator, such as the bronze whaler shark, has no natural predators. In the temperate waters of the ocean off South Africa the shark can find vast quantities of sardines to eat.

“Each species has a specific place in nature, in geographic location and in the food chain.”

Carl Linnaeus

Food webs

Observers after Bradley suggested that animals were not simply part of a food chain, but a larger and more complex “food web” that comprises all the food chains in a location. This idea was put forward by Dutch naturalist John Bruckner in 1768, and later taken up by Charles Darwin, who called the variety of connected feeding relationships between species a “web of complex relations”.